# Nothing Gold Can Stay: Text & Annotation Guide

Robert Frost (1923) | natural metaphors, allusion, and connections to The Outsiders



## *Nothing Gold Can Stay*

Robert Frost | 1923 | 8 lines, rhymed couplets

A
1 *Nature's first green is gold,*
2 *Her hardest hue to hold.*

B
3 *Her early leaf's a flower;*
4 *But only so an hour.*

C
5 *Then leaf subsides to leaf.*
6 *So Eden sank to grief,*

D
7 *So dawn goes down to day.*
8 *Nothing gold can stay.*

### KEY TERMS

**Allusion:** a brief reference to a well-known person, text, or event.
**Metaphor:** a direct comparison without like or as.
**Personification:** giving human traits to nature.
**Hyperbole:** deliberate exaggeration.
**Hue:** a color.
**Motif:** an image that repeats through a work, like the sunsets in the novel.

### THINK ABOUT IT

*Frost's last line is a statement. Johnny's version is a command. What changes when 'nothing gold can stay' becomes 'stay gold'?*

### A — Lines 1-2 *Personification + color metaphor*

Frost gives Nature a gender and a will (**Her**). New spring buds often show a golden green, so **gold** stands for the freshest, purest stage of life. **Hue** means color, and **hold** means both to keep and to grasp: the brightest moment is the hardest to keep.

**Outsiders link:** Johnny's and Ponyboy's youth is the green-gold the poem describes.

MY ANNOTATION

### B — Lines 3-4 *Metaphor + exaggeration*

An early leaf looks like a flower, so the first growth seems like blossom. **Only so an hour** is hyperbole: the beauty lasts almost no time. The rhyme of **flower** and **hour** underlines how fast it passes.

**Outsiders link:** Pure moments are brief: the Windrixville sunrise Ponyboy shares with Johnny.

MY ANNOTATION

### C — Lines 5-6 *Allusion to the Garden of Eden*

**Leaf subsides to leaf**: the special color fades into ordinary green. **So Eden sank to grief** alludes to the Garden of Eden in Genesis, where perfect innocence is lost. Frost compares the fading of spring to the fall from innocence.

**Outsiders link:** Violence and loss end innocence for the boys; Dally is hardened by it.

MY ANNOTATION

### D — Lines 7-8 *Image of time + conclusion*

**Dawn goes down to day** uses sunrise as an image of the same fading. The final line is a flat, short statement: **Nothing gold can stay**. The poem accepts that change is natural and unavoidable, which is its central idea.

**Outsiders link:** Johnny turns the poem into a request: 'Stay gold, Ponyboy.'

MY ANNOTATION